the material, which we used in our testimony before the commission of inquiry. The second described the sources without actually identifying them. As we arrived at our first appearance before the committee, we deposited all of the intelligence material into the hands of the secretary of the committee. One of the committee members asked us to leave the list of sources with the secretary as well. The director of the Mossad then turned to the group and warned them that those names were among the most important and compartmentalized sources of the Mossad and that most of them continued to provide intelligence. Half-joking, he added, “Look, I have no choice but to know who these sources are, and I assure you that that’s why I sleep very badly at night.” At that point, the committee members held a brief consultation, after which they decided to make do with the index containing only the description of the sources, with our understanding that if they asked for a source to be identified during the hearings we would provide them with the information. We kept the first index with us at all times.

The second working assumption is that the “need to know” principle must be strictly observed within the system. There are two aspects to this principle. On the one hand, it is intended to ensure that anyone who does not need to receive a piece of intelligence will not do so, thereby increasing the protection of the source. But what is more important is to ensure that the piece of intelligence does reach everyone who needs to see it. This is perhaps the most difficult problem in information sharing—how to ensure that every bit of intelligence reaches the people who need it in order to carry out their job. Of course, the story of the Saudi students, al-Qaeda men who learned how to fly and later carried out the attacks of September 11, 2001, illustrates this point. A few months before the attacks, CIA director George Tenet and national coordinator for counterterrorism Richard Clarke were convinced of an impending “spectacular attack,” and in July a warning was received from a credible source that al-Qaeda was planning a large-scale operation in the United States. Though the names of some of the Saudis who were training to be pilots were known to some of the intelligence agencies, the terrorists succeeded in carrying out their plan. With hindsight analysis, it was argued that if all of the US intelligence agencies had shared their information with each other, the attacks would have been avoided. However, a 1995 Justice Department order severely limited the ability of these agencies to share information obtained by listening in on telephone conversations. In his 2004 testimony to the national commission